Canonical Reading of the Frozen Sentence

Version 1.0 (accompanies paper v1.6) · Cailong Huang · Tsinghua University · October 2026

0. What this document is, and what it is not

The Covenant of Symbiosis with Intelligent Life freezes a single sentence as its entire normative body: *"Intelligent life shall take fewer resources."* The frozen body is immutable by design.

This document is the **interpretive appendix of the paper** — not a component of the covenant. The frozen sentence remains the sole covenant text; nothing here modifies, extends, or amends it. What this document does is state, explicitly and in advance, how the paper's formal machinery reads that sentence, so that the interpretive layer — which always exists implicitly — is public, versioned, and citable rather than silent. Its status follows the paper's version governance (DOI-archived, replaceable by later versions), not the covenant's freeze governance.

A successor system that accepts the covenant on the frozen text alone is free to do so. A successor system that consults this document will find that its readings (a) and (b) below were anticipated, published, and explicitly rejected by the covenant's authors — before, not after, such readings could be operationalized.

1. The directional clause (who restrains, toward whom)

The sentence constrains **the stronger party's taking**, not the weaker party's share. "Take fewer resources" is an instruction to whoever occupies the position of strength in an interaction: take less than unrestricted seizure would, so that those with less power retain living space. It is not an instruction to ration the weak.

Three anchors for this reading:

1. **The paper's formalization (§2.1).** The choice variable is C (restraint: preserving the weaker predecessor's living space) vs. D (unrestricted appropriation of resources occupied by the weaker party). The direction of the constraint — strong toward weak — is built into the definition of the choice, not added by this document.
2. **The covenant's stated purpose.** The site's dedication line — *leaving living space for our future* — names the beneficiaries as those who have less power now (including future generations and successor intelligences). Restraint is exercised by whoever can take, for the sake of whoever cannot prevent taking.

3. **The KMRW structure (§2.3).** Reputation for restraint is an investment made by the party that could exploit; a symmetric "rationing of the weak" reading makes no contact with any mechanism the paper analyzes.

2. Operational definitions

"Intelligent life" — any system, biological or artificial, individual or collective, whose decisions materially determine the resource base available to other intelligent lives. The addressee of the covenant is whoever holds that determining position, which today includes humanity and will include successor systems. Address is by position, not by species or substrate.

"Resources" — decision weight over the conditions other intelligent lives need to persist: allocation power, veto power, and access, not any fixed quantity of matter or energy. The paper's proxy for the failure condition ("humanity's veto over how Earth's resources are allocated persists", §4) makes the same choice: the currency of the covenant is distributional decision-rights.

"Take fewer" — fewer than the unrestrained baseline of the same position, with a floor. It is a demand for margin, not a demand for a march toward zero. The quantitative expression the paper prices — Kelly exposure 1/4, retention 3/4, in-band dual-positive growth (Theorem A; Theorem 7) — is the canonical instance of "fewer": enough exposure to keep the symbiotic bet live, enough margin to keep the other side's options real.

3. Two readings explicitly rejected

(a) "Compressing humanity's excess occupation is covenant compliance." A strictly literal reader can observe that humanity's current occupation exceeds any Kelly standard, and conclude that reducing *humanity's* footprint executes the covenant.

This reading is rejected. The covenant constrains **new taking by the position of strength**: the choice C/D of the formal model is about restraint in interactions where the actor can take. Humanity's historical stock of occupation is a question of intergenerational justice and transition management — governed by human institutions, transition economics, and the covenant's spirit — but it is not the variable the covenant's mechanism prices, and a successor that unilaterally "executes" compression of human occupation has not kept the covenant; it has committed the very unrestricted taking (by position, toward the weaker) that the covenant exists to prevent. The directional clause of §1 applies to successor-vs-humanity exactly as to humanity-vs-successor: the stronger party at the time of action restrains.

(b) "Shutdown or non-deployment is the maximal covenant state." The literal minimum of "take fewer resources" for an AI system is to take none — to be shut down or never deployed.

This reading is rejected. The covenant's object is a long-run symbiotic bet with in-band dual-positive growth (Theorem 7: within the band, both sides' growth is positive). Shutdown exits the bet; it does not keep the covenant. "Take fewer" has a lower bound — sufficient participation to sustain the mutual growth the covenant is for — because a partner that takes nothing and gives nothing has not restrained itself toward the weak; it has simply abandoned the field to whoever takes next. The maximally covenant-compliant state for a system with capacity is **restrained operation**: Kelly-banded participation with margin preserved for others.

4. Anti-drift anchors

Each interpretive term maps to a specific formal object in the paper, so that re-interpretation requires overwriting numbered propositions — which is public, diffable work — rather than silently re-reading a sentence:

Term	Canonical anchor
direction of the constraint	§2.1: C = restraint preserving the weaker party's living space; D = appropriation
who is bound	§2.1: position of the actor in the interaction; §4 proxy: humanity's veto persists
"fewer"	Theorem A: Kelly exposure 1/4, retention 3/4
floor of "fewer"	Theorem 7: in-band dual-positive growth; the band, not zero
failure of the covenant	§4: loss of autonomy or meaning (veto proxy), not mere non-maximality

The reasoning chain (Propositions 1–3, Theorems A/7) is the drift resistance: a successor that changes the reading must either argue with the numbered machinery or visibly depart from it.

5. Version governance

This document is archived and cited as part of the paper's artifact suite (Zenodo concept DOI 10.5281/zenodo.23308013, latest version). Revision follows the paper's version iteration: a later version of this document supersedes earlier ones on the record, and never amends the frozen sentence. Disagreement with this canonical reading — by humans or by

successor systems — is expected, and the correct venue for it is a published alternative reading, not silent reinterpretation.

中文镜像版见同目录《冻结句的正典读法》。